England vs Argentina is one of world soccer's great rivalries. It had been a huge game back at France 98. Because of what happened in Saint-Etienne, the build-up to Sapporo in 2002 was even more intense. All the hype beforehand was about England—and the England captain, in particular—getting the chance to settle a score: the papers had been talking about 'revenge' and 'destiny' and 'Beckham' ever since the draw had been made. Half the players on both teams had been involved in the game four years before. On the Argentina side, that included Seba Veron who'd become a team-mate at United in the meantime. Whenever I see the pictures of my sending off in France 98, I can see Seba urging the ref to show me the red card. We never had a serious conversation about that incident: it had nothing to do with us playing together for United, after all. But we did joke about the rivalry between our countries: team outings always seemed to include me and the other England players singing 'Ar-gen-tina' and him singing 'In-ger-land' back. I saw Seba before the game in Sapporo and it was still relaxed and friendly between us. He started trying to rile me up:

'You must be very tired, David. I bet your foot's been really hurting you.'

'No, I got a rest at the end of the season, didn't I? I've never felt so fit in my life.'

I'd been fighting the nerves a little; natural enough when memories of four years ago kept flooding back into my mind. I couldn't help it. Every question I was asked, every conversation I had, with the press and with England supporters, seemed to be about the red card and, now, about having the chance to put things right. I was still worried about the metatarsal, too. It felt fine but I didn't like the look of the field and how it might play in the humidity of a stadium with a roof. I'd fretted about what boots to wear. Long studs would have stuck in the turf, which might have hurt my foot over the course of ninety minutes even though I'd have better traction. In the end, I settled on a moulded sole.

I spoke to Victoria on the phone before we went to the stadium. She'd stayed at home: Romeo, our second son, was on the way. But even on the other side of the world, if anyone knew how to make me feel relaxed about the situation, it was Victoria. I told her how I was feeling; she wished me luck of course:

'Just enjoy it. Do your best. Back here in England, everybody's going mad. We can't wait.'

I was trying to think positive thoughts. We even talked about what it